RTS·2027

ASHFALL · THE WAR FOR THE SURFACE



FIELD MANUAL

Operations handbook for commanders of the Authority, the Directorate, the Left Behind and the Overseas Expedition

PILOT EDITION · DATA OF BUILD E059F0F

OPEN SOURCE · GPL V3

WINDOWS



FACTION ONE · THE PROTAGONISTS

THE CONTINENTAL RECONSTRUCTION AUTHORITY

"Count the living, mend the line." — teletype header, every message since 1963.

FOUNDED	February 1963, the Lakeshore Conference
SEAT	The Administration, answering to the Charter
FIELD COMMANDER	Brigadier Hester Wrenfield
COLOURS	Working grey, olive, safety yellow
PLAYS LIKE	Slow, armoured, very hard to dislodge. The best artillery on the continent.

A GOVERNMENT OF CLERKS AND ENGINEERS



The Authority is governed by councils of the people who keep things running: grid engineers, rail dispatchers, agricultural surveyors, county clerks. Each district elects a Reconstruction Board, the boards send delegates to the Administration, and the Administration answers to a Charter that nobody is allowed to rewrite on a Tuesday. Decisions are slow, minuted and filed in triplicate, and the Authority is proud of it. Slow is how it survived the First Winter without a single coup.

Its people are not united by a leader or a flag but by a ledger. Everyone is counted; everyone is owed a ration, a roof and a hearing. The price is a labour year, served by every citizen in work crews, convoy service or the militia.

THE RELUCTANT ARMY

The Authority does not want a war. It wants a working grid, a census that adds up, and fields it can plant. The Charter still contains the clause that will dissolve the Authority when its work is done, and the soldiers know it.

That reluctance is also a weakness. The Authority will fortify, repair and wait long past the point where an enemy would have attacked, and it will count the cost of every shell before it fires one.

HOW THE AUTHORITY FIGHTS

The army is the labour year with rifles. Its doctrine is the surveyor's: find the ground, hold the ground, then improve the ground. A base has a perimeter, a power grid and a road out. Armour goes forward behind sealed transports because ash kills unprotected infantry, and every column carries clean water.

COUNT THE LIVING · MEND THE LINE

COMMANDER'S NOTES · DRAFT TEXT

Build power before anything else and keep a surplus: every Authority structure draws on it. Your Refinery is expensive (2000) but delivers a free Scraper. Defend with turrets and infantry while the Vehicle Factory comes up; the Heavy Tank is the backbone of every column. Engineering Works opens tier 2, the Signals Headquarters tier 3.

HEAVY TANK 800

Main battle armour · Tier 1 · tracked



COST	800 credits
BUILD TIME	16 s
ARMOUR	400 HP · heavy
SPEED	1.56 cells/s
SIGHT	5 cells
WEAPON RANGE	5 cells
DAMAGE / RELOAD	60 / 2 s
REQUIRES	Vehicle Factory

DAMAGE AGAINST



The backbone of the Authority's armoured columns, a slab-sided tracked tank with a small sealed reactor and a long cannon. They are built slowly, serviced obsessively and rarely lost. Crews say the hull plate is thick because the Administrator is cheap and wants his tanks back.

```
ARMOUR 5 // MAIN GUN, TRACKED, REACTOR CORE
SEALED. DO NOT FOLLOW IT INTO ITS OWN SMOKE.
STOP.
```

Use it for: light vehicles, armour. **Keep it away from:** infantry, defences.

SCRAPER 700

Armoured ashfall harvester · Tier 1



A squat armoured crawler built at the Vehicle Factory, with a plough blade, a sealed cab and a lead-lined hopper. Its crew are the most respected workers in a reconstruction town, since every ration depends on how full the hopper comes back. Drivers paint the names of their children on the hull.

```
SCRAPER 3 // SEALED CAB, FULL HOPPER. RETURN TO
REFINERY AT DUSK. STOP.
```

COST	700 credits
BUILD TIME	14 s
ARMOUR	350 HP · heavy
SPEED	1.41 cells/s
SIGHT	4 cells
REQUIRES	Vehicle Factory

RIFLEMAN 100

Citizen-army infantry · Tier 1



Raised from the barracks by the labour-year draft, the rifleman is a clerk, a lineworker or a farmhand with a service rifle and a month of drill. He is not a hero, and the Authority does not ask him to be one. He is asked to hold a position until the armour arrives, and to stay out of the ash.

COST	100 credits
BUILD TIME	2 s
ARMOUR	50 HP · unarmored
SPEED	0.94 cells/s
SIGHT	4 cells
WEAPON RANGE	3 cells
DAMAGE / RELOAD	8 / 0.75 s
REQUIRES	Barracks

> FIELD MAN 1 // SERVING CITIZEN. HOLDS GROUND. REQUIRES DECON AFTER ASHFALL EXPOSURE. STOP.

DAMAGE AGAINST



ROCKETEER 300

Anti-armour infantry · Tier 1



Trained at the same barracks as riflemen but on tube-guided launchers that need a steady hand and a clear lane. Each rocket is hand-counted into the inventory and signed for on return. Rocketeers are the Authority's answer to anything armoured that gets too close.

COST	300 credits
BUILD TIME	6 s
ARMOUR	60 HP · unarmored
SPEED	0.78 cells/s
SIGHT	5 cells
WEAPON RANGE	5 cells
DAMAGE / RELOAD	100 / 3.75 s
REQUIRES	Barracks

> ROCKET SECTION 2 // HEAVY AND SLOW. KEEP BEHIND THE LINE. DO NOT WASTE ROUNDS. STOP.

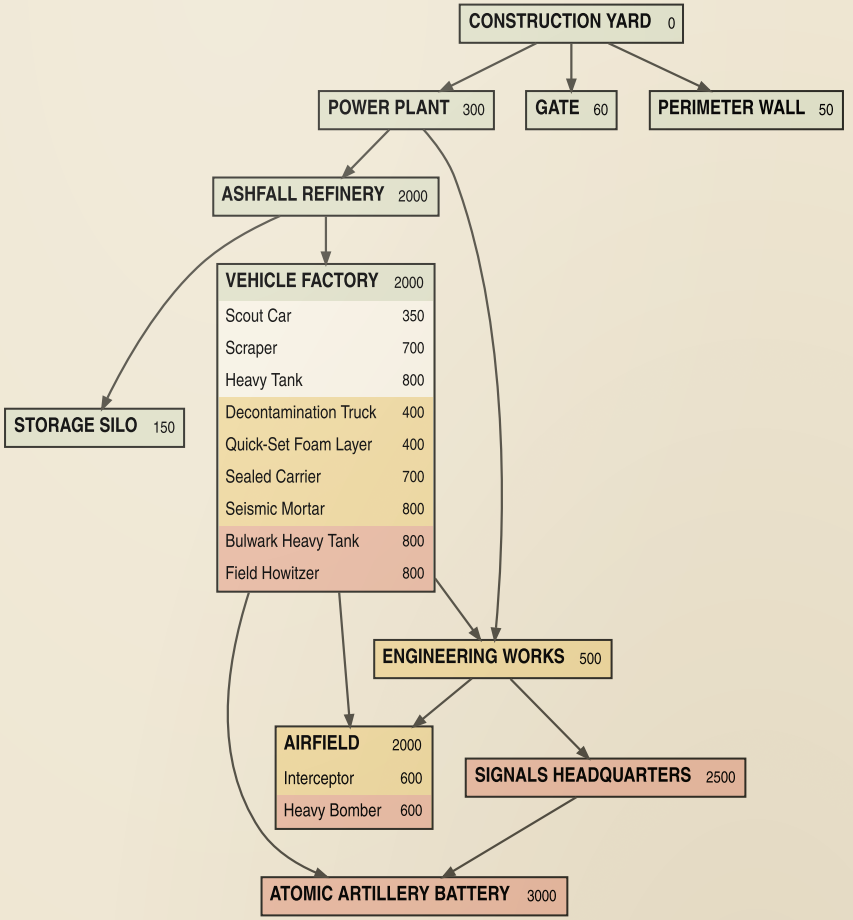
DAMAGE AGAINST



PART III · TECHNOLOGY

AUTHORITY TECHNOLOGY TREE

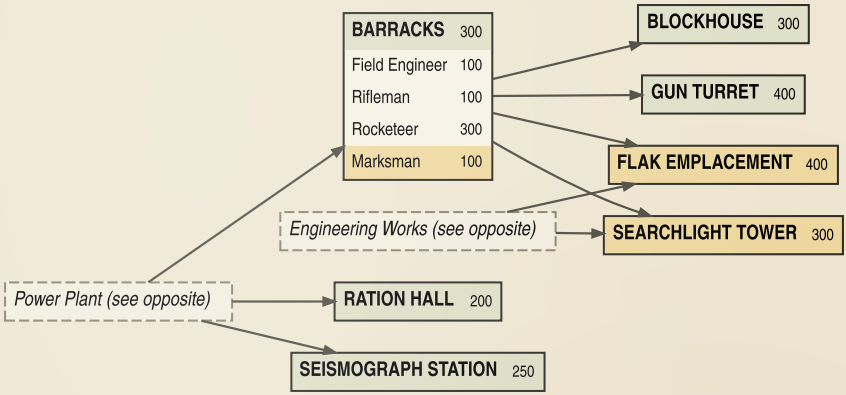
Everything starts at the Construction Yard. Arrows point from a building to what it opens. Units are listed under the building that trains them; numbers are credits. This page: the economy and the heavy branch.



Tier 1 · Tier 2 (Engineering Works) · Tier 3 (Signals HQ)

INFANTRY AND DEFENCES

The infantry branch hangs off the Power Plant. Dashed boxes are on the opposite page.



RESEARCH · AT ANY RESEARCH BUILDING	
Convoy Drill	T1 · 800
Flak Vests	T1 · 800
Foundation Grouting	T2 · 1500
Composite Armour	T2 · 1500
Sodium Lamps	T2 · 1500
Signals Net	T3 · 2500
Tungsten Shot	T3 · 2500

READING THE TIERS

Tier 2 opens when an Engineering Works stands; tier 3 when a Signals Headquarters stands. Lose the building and the tier closes again until you rebuild it, so guard them. In the campaign, new tech is issued mission by mission as the Administration releases it.

PART I · THE WORLD

THIRTY-NINE YEARS AFTER THE EXCHANGE

For nine days in October 1962 a standoff that everyone expected to end at the brink did not. The war never had a surrender; it simply ran out of things to throw. What was left was a continent of fires, broken power lines and a sky the colour of a bruise — and, under it all, the grey drift the survivors learned to mine: **ashfall**.

Oct 1962	The Exchange. In nine days the major cities of the continent are struck.
Nov 1962	A sealed government complex closes its blast doors from the inside. It calls itself the Interior Annex.
1962–63	The First Winter. Engineers, utility crews and rail dispatchers keep towns alive by hand.
Feb 1963	The Lakeshore Conference signs the Charter of Reconstruction. The Authority is born.
1968	The first armoured scraper takes ash from a field; a centrifuge turns it into reactor fuel.
1979	The Convoy Roads open across the Rust Belt.
1985	The Voice begins the Reclamation broadcasts: the Directorate will take the surface back.
1990	The Great Drift buries the Glass Coast.
Spring 2000	A survey convoy on the Rust Belt road goes silent. The search party finds a hatch and a loudspeaker.
2001	The Directorate surfaces openly. The war begins.

THE AUTHORITY CAMPAIGN

1. **SURVEY CONVOY**
   Two scrapers, one jeep, four riflemen and a pitchblende claim in the north-east. The scrapers are the mission.

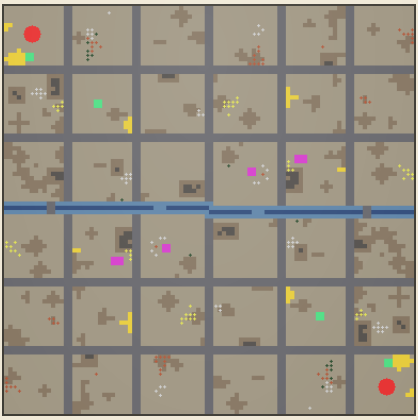
2. **THE JUNCTION**
   All the grain and all the fuel cross one road junction. The relief column will not enter it open.

3. **THE COAST ROAD**
   Get the survey parties to the Glass Coast before the window closes. The dunes are not empty.

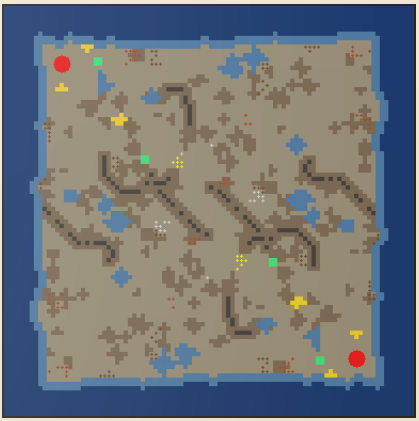
4. **THE SUNRISE DEVICE**
   An old weapon of the Exchange is awake on the south bank, and the countdown has started.

THE FOUR THEATRES

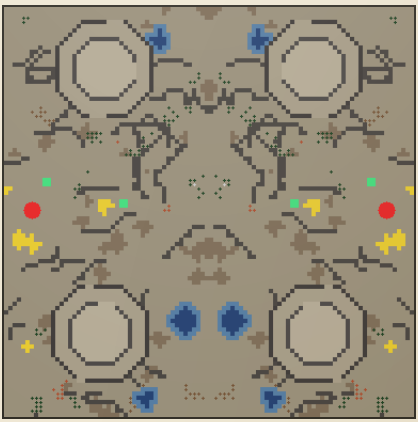
Every skirmish map is drawn from one of four theatres. Each has its own ground, its own resources and its own way of hurting the careless. Read the ground before you build on it.



RUST BELT — a grid of dead towns and convoy roads, cut by one river. Fast lanes, many angles of attack.



GLASS COAST — fused sand and open sea. The Expedition's home ground; watch the water.



MOUNTAINS — ridges and passes. Few routes, so chokepoints decide games.



ASH PLAINS — wide open drift. Rich fields, nowhere to hide.

READING A MAP

Red circles mark starting positions. Yellow is an ashfall field, green a rich pitchblende pit, magenta a neutral ruin you can garrison. Small discs are rubble and wrecks that block movement; blue is water. Your first field is close to home; the richer ones are always where your enemy can reach them too.